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Bill Easley

Bill Easley is a fourth generation musician and fashioned a career as a woodwind specialist. He has performed and recorded with a diverse list of artists, from Isaac Hayes to the Duke Ellington Orchestra.

Bill was interviewed via Zoom on November 1, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Bill —

BE: Hold on one second, oh. Got it. Got it.

MR: Got it?

BE: Wait a minute. I have to press got it.

MR: Okay. Yeah, now you look good.

BE: All right.

MR: Okay. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Bill Easley for my guest here for the Fillius Jazz Archive. And you are zooming in from where?

BE: Durham, North Carolina.

MR: It looks nice there. And I'm in —

BE: Oh it's lovely weather. I don't leave my house. I just am comfortable here, I don't go anywhere.

MR: All right. When you describe what you do, because you've had a very versatile career, when you describe what you do, do you have a sort of short way of summing it up?

BE: Well music is my livelihood. My life is about the study of human behavior, human growth and development, and I am 75 and I would like to become a psychiatrist but they told me I would have to go to school, but I have always been an amateur psychologist my whole life, and music is just what I do to pay my bills.

MR: Being a musician and being in all these different situations, did your intense behavior at looking at other people's behavior, did music give you a chance to observe a lot of different kinds of personalities?

BE: Sure. And some people, you know they have certain things that they think are unique to musicians. By my study musicians are just people just like everybody else. And some of them, Cannonball made a statement one time on "Live to New York" and he talked about people who act like they're supposed to be hip or something. Do you remember that statement?

MR: I do.

BE: I heard that as a teenager and it resonated in my head because he wasn't talking about musicians per se but people in general, they just try to pretend that they're something, you know, rather than being themselves.

MR: Um hum. Yes that statement made a big impression on me as well. How did your family come to live in Olean, New York?

BE: My mother's family was there for hund — oh from the 1800s or early 1900s. My great [gap] migrated from Pennsylvania. My mother's grandfather was a barber and sort of an intellect you know. And my mother's father was an electrician, in fact an inventor. Olean, as you know about the area, it wasn't a large black population there in Olean so my street that I grew up on, South Third Street, in my lifetime was a totally, totally, totally integrated street. In other words you had diverse people, all kinds of people. So I grew up in a world of diversity. And there was all kinds of people and I'm not saying that race was somewhat — was a factor. I didn't have any black school teachers back in the 40s or 50, there were no black professional people in my hometown that I knew, but music was a big part of my family. My grandmother graduated from a conservatory in Meadville, Pennsylvania in the 1800s. And music was huge in my house, in other words it was filled with music and you know, it was joyous, joyous, not just music but very intelligent people. So in looking back, and my sister, I had older sisters that grew up during the depression. I came along when things were much better.

MR: Did the Easley family create a reputation in Olean and the surrounding area as those music people? Call them when you need music?

BE: Well actually my mother, that was the Barnes family, you see. Barnes. And say for instance my mother's mother, my grandmother is the one that went to conservatory in Meadville, Pennsylvania. But her father was a band master. In other words he played all the instruments — back like John Philip Sousa or something back in the day, and he played all of the instruments and his son, which would have been my great uncle Darwin played saxophone and my mother's brother Darwin played saxophone. So I'm a fourth generation musician but a third generation saxophone player.

MR: If I could go back in time and drop in on a gig that you were on when you were about fifteen with the family band and write down every tune that you played, what would some of those titles be?

BE: Well naturally it's all the American Songbook. Gershwin, Cole Porter, you know, Sophisticated — Duke Ellington. We played the same songs that I played the major portion of my livelihood for 62 years, you understand? The same songs. Now funny story, my father, in other words we traveled because we worked all in the immediate area, the towns in Pennsylvania, say for instance I don't know if you'd call it a territory band, but we'd travel maybe forty, fifty miles to Emporium, Pennsylvania or the Wellsville

Country Club and all of these various things, and back. And so we traveled in a car and you had an upright bass and the sound system and a set of drums so you'd all get in one car and go to the gig. And we'd set up and, but my father after setting up the drums, every time he'd say, "Oh what are we going to play? What are we going to play?" Uh, "Almost Like Being in Love." Because he'd call the same tune every night. And he would say it and play an intro and then he'd sing the song and the party was on.

MR: Is that because you played it as a businessman's bounce?

BE: Well I made a record called "Businessman's Bounce."

MR: I know you did that's why I asked.

BE: And it stemmed from the term musicians used to use back in those days, and so it's hard to explain how things, how different things were back — a musician back in those days knew that his job was to make people feel good. And the people would, when they walked, be it a country club or a juke joint or a jazz club or whatever, people walked into a club or wherever you were playing, and they'd worked hard all week long and they would come in with almost like a challenge and it was like, "Make me feel good." That was — and you knew that that's what your job was. So say for instance if you're playing a dance or a country club the whole thing was okay get the people out on that dance floor. And you'd play a tune and then sometimes they're reluctant and resistant. So they would sit there. And so, "Okay what do we play?" And so we'd try and think, "Let's play 'Stardust'." And then he'd say, he'd call a tune and he'd say, "Businessman's Bounce." Which was like a two-beat [scats]. And most people can count to two. And they would get out on the dance floor and they'd move one foot on this beat and one foot on this beat, and the next thing you know they thought they were dancing. And at some point you would make people swing who had no intentions of swinging and didn't know what swinging was, but when they got set then they know that it felt good. So that was pretty much the psychology of the deal.

MR: Yeah I love it when you do that and somewhere after they get started you switch to 4/4 —

BE: There you go.

MR: And they'll respond to that.

BE: Oh yeah, yeah. I'm trying to think of this one tune of Cannonball's. And that's, not just, you know not just the musicians who really knew how to take people on the journey, they knew how to do that. And it would evolve. It would start, like I say [scats] — and then eventually two-spot. But eventually it turned into a circle to where it was like what it's all about.

MR: Yeah. What did your father think of the rock & roll intrusion into pop music?

BE: Okay, well that kind of came much later. I mean that was in the 50s or you know going into — there wasn't no such thing — they had rhythm & blues but rock & roll, see

you've got to realize my father's band it started from 1928. My father came to Olean, New York. He was on the road with a five piece band and somehow, you know you've got to realize it was the roaring 20s so to speak and there was all kinds of live music and speakeasies, and musicians traveling all over the place. Sometimes the musician would answer an ad in a magazine looking for a saxophone player who reads and fakes and so on. A guy may go halfway across the country looking for work. That's how it was, and I sort of caught the tail end of that kind of procedure.

MR: So at what point did you get the idea, or were you forced into, being an improviser?

BE: It was automatic. Because I heard music from the womb. In other words I heard, my mother played piano up until the say I was born, you know playing at the local Moose Club or something like that and she's pregnant. And so I literally, and I have no documentation, but I pretty much learned the American Songbook in the womb. And improvisation, naturally when I started listening to, when I started playing and listening to records and understood what improvisation was, right away, say for instance I'm listening, as a teenager I'm listening to Cannonball and John Coltrane. So when I would get on the job I would be ready to stretch out. And my father would hit the snare drum and he'd say, "Play the melody." And I'd look around like oh you big square. But I wouldn't say that to him because I was afraid. So I had to learn absolute correct mel — and to this day I can play straight melodies, much of it has to do, and in order to do it back in those times you had to learn the words to a song so you could understand the rhythm of the music. So that's something that I've always, that I've done from instinct or being forced, and understanding the importance of it, but there's a lot of great, great, great, great players and improvisers that if you ask them to play a straight melody they wouldn't be able to do it to save their lives. You understand? So that's very common.

MR: It's interesting you say that because I was listening to your recording of "For All We Know" and it was simply gorgeous.

BE: Why thank you.

MR: So much respect for the melody. And then I'm hearing shades of Cannonball in your sound.

BE: Wow.

MR: Something about your vibrato.

BE: I wish. He's my all-time favorite.

MR: Me too. He was my all-time favorite, still is. Can you recall what an average gig with this family band, what kind of money did you make?

BE: Okay, back then you have to realize that my house was a musician's union, see? So scale in 1964, no in the late 50s in other words scale, basic scale was $12 for sidemen and then the leader was 5 dollars extra for the leader. And scale was minimum wage so to speak, if

you're a union musician. Scale was $12 for the sideman and $5 extra for the leader. So the first job that I played with my father when I was about 13 years old was a high school dance. And I just, I played just clarinet at that time and so, by this time I'm going out to jam sessions with my brother-in-law and going to bars and things, to Sunday jam session. So my mother figured well since he's hanging in these bars we might as well, you know, let him play with us. So my first job that I made, my father gave me the $5 which was the extra that he made, but after that one job — I had one job for $5 and from that point on I was a $12 man. In other words I wanted the whole deal. So I got $12, and I bought — my father signed for a bank loan for me to get my first decent clarinet which was a Selmer Series 9 clarinet and it cost $330, so I had a bank loan and he signed for the loan but it was my bill. So I had to at least get one gig a month to pay for my bill. I had bills when I was 13.

MR: That's growing up quickly.

BE: You're telling me.

MR: And when did the saxophone come into the picture?

BE: Well once I paid off my clarinet. You know I was a junior in high school by then you understand, and the clarinet, because I started paying for it in the eighth grade, so in the early part of my — I didn't start even playing the saxophone until I was a sophomore. I'd been playing on these jobs just playing clarinet. I started playing, I had a school horn, a tenor, when I was a sophomore. So then I had a Selmer clarinet so I wanted a Selmer saxophone. A Selmer saxophone in that day and age was $610. So I paid off my clarinet and got another loan for $610 and my payments were $14.75 a month. And I paid that all through my junior year, senior year, and I worked construction after my senior year, that summer. So when I left home in September I paid off my debt for my tenor and that's how I got my horns.

MR: Did you go to Buffalo to buy —

BE: Yeah I used to go there to see people and do the colored musicians' club and things when I was a little boy.

MR: Yeah. They still have that there.

BE: Yup, absolutely.

MR: So you could have obviously gone into music but did your parents want you do?

BE: Oh I don't think my mother — she was all right with it. My father had no interest in being a musician. He was a musician out of necessity you know, to make money. But he was more of an organizer, more of a leader of men. He had the greatest gift of gab of anybody that I've ever met on this planet or probably any other planet. He had the gift of gab. A lot of people think I talk a lot, they never met Bob Easley. He could talk the paint off a wall.

MR: Was a move to New York City a logical step at that time for a young musician?

BE: Well my sister had gone to New York before I had. She worked, and at that time she worked with, she had made a record with Sal Salvador had a big band. And my sister was a singer in the band. And she went to New York a few years before I even thought about going to New York. I don't think I would have gone to New York had my sister not gone there before I did.

MR: Did, just one more question about Olean, as a high school student did music give you an identity in the school? I mean some young men excel at being an athlete. I'm just wondering if you had this reputation as an outstanding musician?

BE: That's a good question because no, I had a reputation as being a football player.

MR: Oh.

BE: I played varsity football as a freshman and I was captain of the football team as a junior. And I wanted to play with the Cleveland Browns, you understand? But I weighed 127 pounds and was 5'5" you understand? And I never got any bigger. I never got any bigger. But I loved — football was my life from the time I was about nine years old. And music was what came second. The only thing — right before the first game of my senior year some kid smaller than me jumped on me and broke my ankle. I never played my senior year. And so the passion that I put into football and sports transferred into the music. Even though I was always serious about music.

MR: So at the age of 19 or 20 there is a term that my classmates used to use when we were in college and it was sort of we want to make it. We want to make it in the music business.

BE: Good, good, good, good, good idea. My thing, my idea of making it, and to this day, from the time I was — I had specific numbers and everything in my head from the time I understood what was going on. But then and now is to be a working musician. And I know that sounds like an oxymoron but no, that's pretty much what my goal was and still is, to be playing music and to work and to make this your livelihood. I've been able to do that for sixty-some years and don't try this at home or don't try this without one hundred percent commitment. That's what's required. And Billy — in your interview with Billy Mitchell you talk about this thing and Billy Mitchell used the phrase to you he said, "Music is a calling." In other words you don't decide you're going to do this, this is just something you're called to do and you do it and pretty much what you do and maybe the reason is 'cause you can't do anything else, I don't know. But as I said I think I could have been a psychiatrist but I'll never get to know.

MR: Well in order to make a living then, I observe in reading about you that a couple of things happened. First of all you learned to play a lot of woodwinds. And second of all you must have had a wide range of music that you decided well I can play with Illinois Jacquet and I can also play with Isaac Hayes.

BE: Um hum.

MR: How did that come about?

BE: Nothing that you decide. If the phone rings you answer it. You know. And you play with whoever — if somebody calls you for a gig and you've got to realize growing up in Olean, New York man, I didn't call myself — we played polkas, we played all kinds of, we played the Sons of Italy and we played all the Italian songs and we'd play pretty much every gig — I could play the "Liechtensteiner Polka," I could play the "Clarinet Polka," you know. That's just how I came up you know. I haven't played a polka in a long time, but I certainly could if somebody called me to play one.

MR: So you learned to read and you became versatile, and when you got to New York you started hanging out, I mean did you — what was your first steady gig in music when you got to New York?

BE: Okay, good question. In other words I worked and saved my money before I went to New York, you know, that summer. And even my sisters gave me a hundred dollars apiece. So I had it all figured — I knew how much money — and I went to Juilliard part time and I had my money set aside for how much my tuition was going to be. I was just going part time, plus I was studying with Joseph Allard. I'm not sure if you know who Joseph Allard was, and that was a great, great, great person to run across at 18 years old you know. And, but my money ran out pretty quickly you know, because, and you've got a room and it's $12 a week or whatever, and you know food. And that money, I thought that money would last for a year but after a few months man I got one of the few day jobs that I ever had in my life and it was working at what was then First National City Bank. And I was making $60 a week on my day job you see. And that was my — but I got into, I started working as a musician pretty soon so I quit that job after a few months because somebody — I was doing occasional jobs anyway, playing here and there. And then I went out on the road with a rock — and they called me at work on Monday. "Man my tenor player didn't call up man, I need you to come and go to Hazelton, Pennsylvania with us. You know? And I'll pay you $125 a week. And I'm making $60 at the bank. And the guy that called me for the gig, he told me at that time that he would pay me $75 on weeks that we didn't work. Naturally that was a big lie, you understand? But I said, so I went to my foreman, oh Walter was his name. I worked in "Incoming Mail" you understand? And my number was 132. And I'd open the mail and I'd put it in the pigeon hole and so on. But I'm hanging out all night 'til 4 o'clock in the morning in these joints sitting in and playing. So I'd get to work man, and if you made a mistake they would call out your number. You know? So all day long you would hear "132" and you'd have to go back and correct the mistake. But it's so funny, so this guy calls me for a gig in Hazelton, Pennsylvania, on a Monday. And I don't even know how he got in touch with me at work

but he called me. And he said, "Man you've got to — we'll pick you up at your apartment house" and so on. So I had to go to my foreman and tell him, "Look man, I just got my big break in show business and I know I should give you two weeks notice." But he said, "No I can't start a prison." So I quit my job and I go out and they are waiting for me uptown. And it was a four piece band and there were three girl dancer/singers. And so I hadn't even met them before. And it's like a station wagon with a trailer pulling the instruments and so on, and there's eight, nine people in there. And I'm like young. I'm like Gomer Pyle. I was Gomer Pyle most of my life. When I think back how Gomer I was back in those days. And so I'm meeting them, "Oh this is our new saxophone player." Before we could get over the George Washington Bridge, and I said, "Oh yeah and I quit my job." And the girls said, "You quit your what?" And I knew that there was probably trouble ahead, and there was, there was. I haven't had a day job since.

MR: A steady gig may be the most accurate oxymoron there is.

BE: There you go. I've never heard of one, unless you work "Cats" for like fifteen years or something like that.

MR: Yeah, we're going to get to that.

BE: Yeah, yeah, all right.

MR: Do you remember back then thinking I want to sound like whom? Did you have influences on alto and tenor or you were just finding your own way?

BE: No, not really. You know in other words I'm still trying to figure out who I want to sound like and I'm very serious, man. I'm still — I mean I adore VanDoren reeds and I think I've finally solved the whole reed thing, you understand? I don't have any more trouble with reeds on each of my instruments. I've got about eight reeds that sound exactly the same and they vibrate exactly the same. And nobody, it works for me and I've given up trying to explain to other saxophone players how to do it or whatever. You know. But sound, but not just the reed but your whole physical thing man. There's a guy on FaceBook, he's a very bright guy and he wrote a book about, a recent book about Johnny Hodges, you know who I'm — a recent book. I'm having a senior moment. We're FaceBook friends and everything. But he put a post on FaceBook, and maybe his best I don't know, he put a post on FaceBook about John Coltrane sounding taller than he was, and that Coleman Hawkins sounded taller, and certain musicians that when you saw them in person you'd be surprised at their height 'cause they sounded so much taller. And people chimed in and they're talking, oh yeah, so and so— and they agreed. And I'm like wait a minute. You know? Sometimes you read somebody's — and you say well maybe I should just shut up. I had to interject and his height had nothing to do with how he sounded you know. And so again, it's best that I don't call names, I hope that he doesn't hear this because he may know I'm talking about him.

MR: Yeah, like sort of searching into another realm of fiction like.

BE: Yeah. Yeah. It's like — well people like to put people in boxes and they say well this group does this and this group does this. And it's such a — at this time man, we're into such a thing that my whole mission is to counter all that that's going on in today's world, you know? And I think I mentioned to you my record that I've got coming out is called "Diversatonic." It addresses, because I've had a very diverse life. It's not about me, it's about society in general, and that, okay we're all different. Get used to it. You understand? That's what bothers me. Because we're so confused. Our whole society is really screwed up, more so than it should be because we made progress and it seems like we're going backwards.

MR: It makes me wonder if there was a period, a decade or a series of years in your life where you felt we were really headed in the right direction as a country?

BE: I think we've made progress all along. In other words now see in history, all I know of for sure is 75 years. And I'm living in a completely different world now than I was let's just say 50 years ago. We changed very much as a society. There are certain basics, with technology — even when I first started playing in other words television was not necessarily, it was new. And so people had to go out to get their fix of joy and social activities. So then you had television, you mentioned rock & roll, that was a big change in society. But now you've got the Internet and cell phones. Most people are walking around with phones that are way smarter then they are, you know, and if you have a question you don't have to ask a pers — you can think of any question that you can possibly think of, and you just talk to your phone and you'll have an answer just like that you know. So but I'm not saying that's a bad thing but I think that people are way less engaging than I remember from years ago you know. Sometimes you can't get two words out of a person. Or if you send a note to a person they're going to answer you with an emoji. They'll send you some initials that you don't even know what they stand for, a statement. Or they'll use some hip phrase or something. I just had it happen. Between the time that we talked earlier I said something to somebody and they wrote back with some phrase and I had to answer them. I said I don't have no idea of what you're talking about.

MR: Yeah. It's like Cannonball, man. You don't decide you're hip, you either are or you aren't.

BE: Well yeah but hipness — but he also said, "Hipness is a state of mind."

MR: That's right.

BE: And so, but that whole speech, now what did he mean by that? And he talked about people who act — he's not just talking about jazz people or so and so. See what people have to understand is you are who you are, so don't pretend to be somebody else. You understand? And don't try to put on some type of act that makes you feel good or makes

somebody think that you're something that you're not. And then that's just human — people do that. That's what human beings do. And it doesn't really work that well you know, the obvious is what it is, you know.

MR: Do you feel you had like an internal voice or something that told you it was time to move on?

BE: Oh yeah, man. See the internal voice, oh my God we could talk four hours about that. Again, I know I talk a lot but let me, let me tell you about the internal voice. Back in the army, stationed in Fairbanks, Alaska. Now around this time I'm 20 years old, right? So at one point I'm trying to figure out what am I going to do when I get out of the Army. Because I'd actually been working, I had a nice steady gig before I got drafted. Now I said when I get out I won't have that youth going for me, and they won't be talking about this little 19-year-old [gap]. Because I'm going to be 20 years old. I'll be like an old man, you understand? So I'm trying to figure out now what am I going to do? So I go on leave and I'm going through — I stopped in Seattle, Washington. And Miles was playing there at a club called — oh I can't think of the name right now. Cannonball made a live record there. I can't think of the name of the club. But Miles Davis, Herbie Hancock, Ron Carter, Wayne Shorter, Tony Williams, they're working at this club. I'm on my way going back to Fairbanks and I've got my army uniform on. So I get this idea, I says I'm going to go to the club and I'm going to go see Miles Davis. And when they take a break I'm going to go up to Miles and say hello Miles, my name is Bill Easley and I play saxophone and so and so, and Miles is probably going to say oh really? Why don't you go get your horn and come play with us. And that's what the voice in my head is telling me that this is how it's going to be you see. So I walked in the club and I'm dressed in my army greens and when they hit it was like some people had come from outer space, man. I had no idea what I was listening to. And I got — it was like an out of body experience and I got up from my chair and I stood right in front of the band and I watched a whole set and they took me to a journey in outer space that I'd never anticipated. By the end of the set my whole idea of going up to Miles and introducing myself disappeared. The voice in my head said, "Go back to your hotel and hide under the bed." You understand? Because this is, in other words you may want to re-think what you want to do. Maybe you will become a chiropractor or something because this music thing may not be for you. But the voice said, clear as a bell, "Just go back to your hotel and just get under the bed." You know. So now I'm trying to get out of the club, I'm trying to leave, and they're changing audiences and I'm — and my hat, I'd left it under the chair where I was originally sitting. You know? So I'm looking all around and I feel these piercing eyes on me, and at the end of Miles' outstretched hand is my army hat. And Miles says, "Is this what you're looking for?" You know. And I grabbed the hat and

I ran out of the club. I just ran out of the club. I didn't even know, remember my name. I just ran out of the club. And so it was devastating but well, you know, there's other things in the world that I could do. Then I go back to the base, clear as a bell the voice in my head said, "You've got to get with a giant. You've got to get with a giant." In other words that means you've got to get with somebody that knows more than you do and so on and so on. So I listened to the voice and I went back to practicing and really getting as serious as I've always been at it. And so I came out of the army in November of '67. By January of '68 I'm out on the road with George Benson. You understand? For two years. And he was a giant. You understand? I'm talking about when we were playing straight ahead, this was before he became a superstar. This is when we were out playing those joints and being on concerts with Miles and with Duke Ellington and with Monk and you name 'em. We're playing at the Vanguard maybe opposite Bill Evans or a week opposite Herbie Hancock and the sextet and so on and so on. So that's where that evolved from that voice in your head.

MR: I'm trying to imagine your thinking about yourself when you were doing those two years with George Benson. Were you happy with your playing?

BE: No. I'd go home and cry every night, you understand? Because George displays all the, George is just — and I was trying to play as many notes as he was and trying to be as technically proficient. And George is one of the greatest players. You know Jimmy Smith, I hung out with Phineas Newborn Jr. I've been around giants you understand? So I know the difference between a giant and a regular player. I got to, say for instance Sonny Stitt took me under his wings maybe about that time or whatever, and I used to hang with Sonny, and I'd try to pick Sonny's brain. And one time I, you know we were playing two weeks in a club uptown. And we'd gotten to be close and he liked me, and kind of thought I was — so I'd asked him what he was thinking and so and so, and then he asked me a few questions — he'd say for instance but you play "I Got Rhythm" and you get to the bridge and what's the first — and he saw me, I couldn't go like [snaps fingers]. So he looks at me very surprised. And he says, "You mean you don't know?" And I said, "Well not really." And he looked and he said, "Well don't worry about it then." Because he knew I could play but I just didn't know what I was doing. You know. But Sonny used to, when we'd hang out and talk and I'd be in his hotel room and we'd play and we'd go over things, Sonny Stitt would — and Sonny was very stern just like the character of Billy Mitchell or whatever. Some of those guys man were very stern. Sonny Stitt would look me right in my face and he'd say, "Bill Easley," you know, "you're a pretty good saxophone player but I am a master." And I'd say, "Well yeah, Sonny, I pretty much know that." You know. So way back then I've always been pretty comfortable that Sonny Stitt thought I was pretty good, man. I still don't have any desire to be a master. But

Sonny Stitt thought I was pretty good you know. Years and years and years later I was living in Memphis, Tennessee and Sonny comes through Memphis and he would travel and play with local rhythm sections and so — but I hadn't seen Sonny in a long time. And by this time I've got a foot of hair and platform shoes and a full beard. And so I go back to the dressing room after the gig to see Sonny Stitt you see. And Sonny Stitt had just come out of being in a coma for 13 days. 13 days he was in a coma. But the thing is you've got to get back to work because you've got to work. You understand? He's got to make money so he's back out working. And so I go back and he's telling me about being in this coma and the fact that he couldn't remember anything of those 13 days. And we're talking and talking about this and talking about different things. I got ready to leave and I'm walking out of the dressing room and Sonny Stitt says to me, he says, "Hey man," he says, "can you tell me how I can get in touch with Bill Easley?" I said, "Well I am Bill Easley." You know. And it was like one of them "Twilight Zone" moments. And I'm thinking man, Sonny Stitt is looking for me you know. So it was what I call one of my mountaintop moments.

MR: Okay. You said — that's a great story. You said something a couple of minutes ago that I want to follow up on. When he was asking you about the bridge to "I Got Rhythm" and you said basically that I know what to do but I don't necessarily know what it is I'm doing. And in this day of intense jazz education where you can study for years and get a Ph.D., I'm wondering how that mindset jives with what we're teaching now?

BE: Well see I — at this late stage in my life I'd like to teach. But see like people in academia avoid me like the plague. You know? They have no interest in me, even though I've done this for sixty-some years. And I've pretty much accepted that by now. But I've had a couple of students near home, they come to my house, and I'm trying to teach as a language more so than a technical — even though see what Sonny Stitt told me about don't worry about it, I didn't — that does not mean that no, you shouldn't learn. The more information that you have the better off you are. But there's different kinds of ways to approach any subject man, there's various different parts of the brain that deal with it this way or this way. You can do the same thing in different ways. You have an intellectual approach to it or you have a certain thing playing by ear — what does that mean and so on and so on. So, because in fact the notes are not the problem it's the space between 'em [gap] and everything else. It's not how your birth date and your death date, it's about all that space in between or how do you get from here to Chicago. You know it's [waves arm]. So that's what music is or any language. It's about the space between. And so that's what sometimes people don't necessarily pay attention to but it's the most important thing. It's about that space between. That's again, I'm not looking for a teaching position or anything like that but I do enjoy teaching in the same way that I've

always taught. I'm not saying I never taught because over the years somebody wanted to, "Man I'd like to study with you, I'd like to study." So well the first problem I have, I don't know what to charge you because I've never been a teacher so I don't know what to charge. So lesson one is free. You come to my house and I'll give you what I think is lesson one. I won't charge. And lesson one is a lesson that I got from Joe Allard way back in 1964, you understand? Joe Allard who had you take your instrument, clarinet or saxophone or it applies on any instrument. And he'd take you through a chromatic sequence of intervals. Now you'd start with a major second up, minor second down, major [scats] you know, a chromatic sequence of intervals. You do seconds, minor seconds up and down. Then expand it. Minor third up, minor third — you know, major second down. A fifth up, you know, diminished fifth down. You know, one note to the next, any music ideas start with two notes [scats]. So the whole thing is mastering one note to the next. And so I would tell the student, now listen, this is something you'll never master but it's something you have to keep working on for the rest of your life. Now we can take that same concept and we can expand upon it and we could write a book as thick as two telephone books, we take and we build major thirds on that movement. Or any four note motif that you come up with, and take it through that cycle in other words and put it in your head and run it through — you know put it on your horn. So that's — it's very basic information and I always do that as lesson one. Nobody ever came back for lesson two, so I never made a dime, you understand? They'd never come back. And I'd see them thirty years later, "Oh man, I'm still working on it." I say well I told you you'll still work on it, but there's more information actually. But very few people want to come. I've got a student now, and he's in another, he's a scientist. He prides himself as taking the most consecutive lessons from me, which is four. You understand? He's trying to break anybody's record, man.

MR: All right.

BE: And you know but he believes me, and there have been a few people over the years that have believed what I was telling them. There was a girl that used to come and take lessons, she came the whole summer. She played the clarinet. And I gave her this idea, that, and then I told her I said, "Now I want you to come up with a four note motif." I said, "Don't even think about it just come up with A, anything A through G, and label it natural, sharp or whatever, and then we'll put it together going up or down, to get to those points. And so she came up with these four notes. [scats] Something, whatever. And so for her next lesson I wrote out this four note — going through the chromatic sequence playing this motif. And her name was [sounds like] Mitsuyo. And I had it all written out for her and the title was "Mitsuyo's Motif." You know. So she looked at it and she was so excited you know. She was so excited that it was her name and it was perfect you know.

And boy she — when she would come for her lesson I'd have to practice a day in advance because she'd be fiddling through this — I'd have to get ready for it. But she's the only one that I had that was that ambitious.

MR: Well that was very astute of you to come up with that.

BE: Yeah, yeah.

MR: So I want to ask you about the Broadway pit band part of your career.

BE: Uh huh.

MR: Those are fairly coveted gigs, aren't they?

BE: Yup. Absolutely. And "Sophisticated Ladies" was the Broadway show. And that came about because of the fact that I had been out — I had been out on the road — right after Duke died I went out with the band for about [gap] months or whatever. But the reason I went out with the band was because Stanley Dance had told Mercer, "Man, you've got to find a clarinet player, because the clarinet is a very important voice in Ellingtonia." And actually it was Jimmy Hamilton had recommended or suggested that I get the gig after he left the band. But it never did materialize at that time. But right after Duke died I went out on the band with Mercer and the only reason I went out was because I was working with Isaac Hayes at that time and this was during a period where he was out making a movie somewhere or something like that. Regarding the band, Mercer was, he said, "Man, you've got an open chair in the band any time you want to come back." So when he came through Memphis one time and they were getting ready, talking about doing a musical on Broadway. So Mercer invited me to come, you know, if you want to come back. So I moved back to New York with the promise of this job on Broadway. And it's sort of what I aspired, the type of work that I aspired to do in my lifetime. I turned down two months when I got to New York in January of 1980, there were three possibilities: going out with Horace Silver, Art Blakey, and going out with Panama Francis and the Savoy Sultans you see. To make a long story short I went out on the road, I turned down the gigs with Blakey and Horace Silver. Because first of all jazz sidemen are the most underpaid workers probably since, you know I don't even want to say. But that's just the history of jazz sidemen, there was some money but jazz sidemen in America are some of the most mistreated people on the planet. And you probably know about that so I won't — I'll spare you the details of how the jazz thing works. So I had a half a jazz career but I've been at enough Broadway shows and enough recording that was more geared toward stability than creativity. I know I talk a lot man. Jump in anytime, because —

MR: Those are great — stability and creativity — I think that's very important for musicians to have a balance there because if they only have stability they'll be one of those grumpy people who just —

BE: Yeah there's a lot of those, right?

MR: Did you have something you did when you were in the pit to help keep focused when you had 84 measures of rest and then you had to come in? Because it's been my observation that, you know when you play a show over and over and over you have these long periods of not playing that your mind can start going out.

BE: You know what? That's a brilliant point. And my experience is totally — because that's the norm. See that's the norm. It's going to the assembly line. You have to realize I had a very, very unique Broadway career. In other words I went to "Sophisticated Ladies" to a show called "Black and Blue" you know which was filled with jazz all-stars. I did "Jelly's Last Jam" where the clarinet was just all throughout the whole thing. And most of my shows have not been your typical Broadway shows, you see they've been jazz-themed shows. And most of my chairs have been with me in mind you see. I've been hired for, you know, "Get Bill Easley" because that's what Bill Easley does. You know. And I bet my experience is not typical. If I'm playing a Broadway show, or anything that I'm playing, I was not involved with the show or the music [gap] is in my face. I'm involved with the whole experience. So no, my norm is not to okay play this and then pick up a book and read a chapter of this. No. If I go to work I'm there to work, and I'm involved with all, not just my part but everything going around me and during — the actors and the singers. In other words I used to go to work every night in "Black and Blue," oh is Sir Roland Hanna going to play tonight. You understand? What is he going to play tonight? You know. And so that, I hate to brag but not many people have had that kind of experience you see.

MR: It's okay with me if you brag.

BE: No, you know, because you'll turn me off. Look, listen man, I can't help but to brag because I've had the best life and, when you talk about them cats that are mad all the time and so and so, I've never been one of those guys. You know I live in three states: the truth, the state of gratitude, and the state of happiness. And everything else is a waste of my time see. And I'm still living that way.

MR: That's wonderful.

BE: Past, present and future all exist simultaneously.

MR: I would think there has to be something that might happen on a bandstand or in a recording studio that would aggravate you. And can you think what it might be? Some kind of behavior, either musically or otherwise, from other musicians that you found —

BE: Yeah when they don't pay me. Oh my God. I get hysterical, are you serious? No, no. No, no. I mean not really. Because I pretty much accept everybody for what they do and what their capability — I played from the greatest, greatest, greatest people on the planet, to the worst that you could ever imagine. And just because somebody is not a great musician doesn't mean that I don't — because as I told you earlier man, I'm into people.

I've met with some monster musicians who I wouldn't go across the street to hang out and have a drink of water with. There's some guys, I've played with a bass player, and he's a lawyer, and I've worked with him for years and years and years. I never heard him play a right note in his life you know. But I actually like going to work with him. And much of my work over the years was going to work, somebody would call me for a gig and I'll play with some people that I've never seen before. And so you make — what do you make out of this? In other words it's a matter, okay, they call you, what's the best that you can make out of this situation? And nobody taught me that or anything, that's just the way it's always been. You play the gig that you're on, not the gig that you were on last week or the gig that you hope to be on next week. You play the gig that you're on tonight. So that's pretty much it.

MR: Thumbs up for that. I love the, on your website you had a series of "Thoughts of the Day." And you seem to be an optimist, because on May 4 of 2020 when things were really bad with Covid, and "isolation is the perfect environment to practice" you said. Preparing for the best outcome — "prepare for the best outcome, the worst outcome will take care of itself."

BE: Yeah I mean that's not rocket science man. Worst always — you know if a tornado hits — you know you try to get out of its way but you don't hope for a tornado. So that's just simple, simple, simple, simple logic man. In other words it's good and bad — two extremes to everything man. Everything that exists exists in ying and yang you know, man/woman, day/night, you know, winter/summer, whatever. Everything — and there's a whole lot in between good and evil. And so good force and evil force, I mean they both exist. And so it's a matter of choice, which do you want to gravitate towards?

MR: Well we've been at this for about an hour, it's been wonderful.

BE: Oh my goodness. I'm going to let you talk next time.

MR: I'm wondering if you have anything to say about the state of our country. Because you are an observer of human nature, and you were just talking about extremes. Do you have anything you can comment on?

BE: Well my current mission man, my current thought and my current project, and it's more, I've got a record coming out in April. I did it here locally in Durham you know. And with guys I didn't really know that well. I brought in a ringer from New York, an organ player by the name of Kyle Kohler. 'Cause I played with all of the great organ players. I probably played with more great organ player than anybody on the planet. Jimmy Smith, Jimmy McGriff, you can't name but maybe two organ players that I didn't play with. So I never made an organ record. This is sort of a record with an organ vibe on it. But the name of it is "Diversatonic" "Diversatonic." And it's inspired by what's going on now and the truth is [gap] stop, man, like worrying about the fact that we're all different man.

Because we are and that's a fact of life. Man, we're all different and you know we should just respect each other for our differences and naturally we don't have to all agree but we have to respect each other or else we're headed toward self-destruction. The fact is simple. It's simple. You know the best way to get some respect is to die, and then everybody be [groans] everybody is interested in you then. But no, respect the living you know, because it's important and we'd have such a better, better world and you know, be concerned with your fellow man. We certainly have enough on earth to go around but yet we have people in terrible shape. And it's been that way since the beginning of time. So life itself and humanity should be about self-improvement. In other words, the goal today is to be better than you were yesterday. And that does not mean — it takes work but it's very important. Why would you want to be worse today, you know, unless things had to get sick and so and so, yes. But spiritually, psychologically, you have to keep trying to be better. Cut me off because I'm on a ramble.

MR: No, no, no. You said it in one of your thoughts, you said "I'm definitely a better musician at 71 than I was at 21."

BE: Oh, I'm better at 75.

MR: And certainly a wiser person.

BE: Absolutely. Absolutely.

MR: Right.

BE: You are too. God I've known you since 1995. You're way smarter. Man, you're way smarter.

MR: I'm going to have to get that in writing, Bill.

BE: I'll write it down.

MR: Well I want to thank you.

BE: I didn't mean to ramble so long. You knew it — when you called me you knew what you were in for just like Billy Mitchell. You knew you were going to catch hell.

MR: I liked it. I appreciate your time.

BE: Hey man, it's been an honor.

MR: Well thank you very much, and best of luck with that new recording, and I enjoy your outlook on life. I can relate very well to it, making a living in music by doing whatever comes up and doing it well.

BE: If it's paying I'm playing.

MR: Okay.

BE: All right my friend.

MR: I'll see you on the flip side.